

to always keep the OS free. On the other hand are companies who built over and around their open source products, especially Linux distributions such as Novell and Red Hat. They usually treat the free versions of their Linux distributions as a testing ground for commercial products. Canonical promises that Ubuntu is, and always will be, free of cost and open in nature. As far as its bank accounts are concerned, the OS is a volunteer-driven project and the company capitalises on its Ubuntu-related support and development services to enterprises. The commitment of Canonical and Mark Shuttleworth are to be credited for the ever-growing fame of Ubuntu.

Why is Ubuntu popular?

For those who're interested in computing, Linux is something which they take pride in being a user of, and love its freedom and flexibility.

Among all the Linux distributions, which already are extremely popular (use Google's free keyword tool to avail salvation for yourself), Ubuntu is the most popular. The reason for its triumph over all other Linux distributions is its ease of use. Before Ubuntu came into picture, Linux was thought of as a real tough nut to crack. Many had the (wrong) notion about Linux being a completely command line based operating system. While it is still true that an extremely rich set of useful applications, programs and features of Linux are dependent on command line (or call it the console), Linux certainly was much more than just a console-driven, type and press Enter styled operating system, even before Ubuntu was born. The one thing it lacked was the real ease of use offered by other operating systems such as Windows and Mac.

Ubuntu changed the scene with its innovative solutions to issues. It ensured that users could download new software easily. The OS was further popularised by the fact that it allowed you to use the system right from the CD and install it only once you felt pleased enough. The installer was simple and the looks were different and beautiful.

Ubuntu software updates were fuss-free even for the regular user to understand. One of its most innovative technical aspects was its self-upgrade feature. You didn't need to download a separate ISO file, burn it to a disk and then install or update from it. All you had to do was upgrade from within the OS. The required files would automatically be downloaded and installed. Version changed! Slowly, many other innovations came in: a music store (just like Apple), a software centre, integration of music